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Removing the spigot

15 Finally, reverse the bowl onto the vacuum chuck and remove the spigot and centre of the foot with the 10mm gouge, leaving the 6mm bead standing proud. The final scraping cuts are made with the gouge on its side, using the horizontal lower wing as a scraper. The same job could perhaps be done more easily with a straight scraper, but sometimes the right tool for the job seems to be the one you already have in your hand! A final sanding and polishing finish the job and it can be removed from the chuck

16 The finished spalted beech bowl should look something like this

It doesn't have to be spalted wood...

17 Finding spalted timber at just the right point for turning can be tricky and it is always difficult to predict just what the outcome will be – but of course, that's part of the attraction. Just as striking and unpredictable as spalted timber, are burrs – or burls – and none more so than those from Australia. Collectively known as 'Goldfield burls', they are more tightly formed than our native oak (*Quercus robur*) or elm (*Ulmus procera*) burrs with fewer cracks, gaps or splits in them, and they take an excellent finish. With this material you have to take what you can get and pieces are often odd shapes that don't lend themselves to conventional bowl making

18 This piece of brown mallee (*Eucalyptus dumosa*) burl was extremely hard and closely knit. Despite drilling the correctly sized pilot hole it was difficult to screw it onto the screw chuck so that holding recesses could be cut in the underside. Reversed first on one recess then on the other, the two bowls were hollowed quite easily with a freshly sharpened gouge, taking very light cuts to maintain clean edges where they overlap. I'm indebted to Philip Streeting for giving me this piece of burr ●

HANDY HINTS

1. When purchasing spalted wood, examine it carefully for regions that have 'gone too far'. In a very real sense, spalting is just another name for rotting and it gradually destroys the fibre structure of the wood making it soft, porous and almost impossible to work to a good finish. If you can dig your fingernail into areas of the timber it is almost certainly going to cause you problems when you attempt to turn it
2. If your spalted timber is wet, put it somewhere where it will dry out fairly quickly, but not so fast that it might crack. Spalting only happens in wet timber. Drying it stops any further spalting
3. If your timber isn't spalted enough then wrap it in plastic film to keep it moist and put it in a warm place to promote spalting. Be sure to check regularly to make sure it's not gone too far. I confess I've never had much luck with this myself
4. There is argument about whether the fungal spores that remain in the timber are harmful or not. I can't give a definitive answer but, about 15 years ago I ended up in hospital with pneumonia caused by fungi – they told me. It may be irrelevant, but I had been turning spalted beech, without a mask, about a fortnight before this diagnosis. Fortunately I recovered, although I still get short of breath very easily. Wear a good quality dust mask of at least PP2 standard
5. It may be worth experimenting with wood hardeners or soaking with cyanoacrylate or epoxy resin etc., to stabilise punky regions and make them easier to turn to a decent finish. There are no magic answers. You have to try it and see
6. Beech is the timber of choice for kitchenware, chopping boards, food bowls and the like, because it is known to be 'food safe'. However, I'm pretty sure that does NOT extend to spalted beech. Do not use it for food contact, babies' rattles or any similar situation where fungal spores may be ingested. It's common sense, isn't it?

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